



Experimentation and the search for hidden patterns in the short story collection "Captivating Wrinkles" by Mohamed Kamel Ben Zid as an example

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Abstract

The Algerian narrative experience has diversified with the multiplicity of its narrative practices, which has led to numerous readings of the single model based on the characteristic of experimentation, which has found its way into contemporary narrative texts seeking to investigate the characteristic of experimentation within the narrative genre under study; and to read what has not been said. Based on this, the research entitled: "Experimentation and the Journey to Search for the Implicit System in the Short Story Collection 'Captuous Wrinkles' by Muhammad al-Kamil bin Zayd as a Model" came to investigate how experimentation embodies the implicit system in the book Captivating Wrinkles.

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1. Introduction

The short story has been an important part of literature, offering a range of different experiences in line with developments in the course of historical and literary change. Those familiar with short stories in Algeria will find that they differ and change according to the querulents of each stage and period. Those who delve deeper into contemporary writing will find a breakthrough in the general principles of dealing with this literary genre. This is through the use of experimentation (l'expérimentation), a technique that allows its users to sail away from the intended meaning towards the production of non-exclusive meanings. Meaning offers its readers a wider space to deal with the idea of the text according to their prior cultural knowledge, as these texts cannot be dealt with superficially. but rather requires a high level of knowledge () that enables them to probe its depth in order to determine its meanings and understand its dimensions. This is made possible by experimentation, which is a mechanism of destruction a imedat discovering new form in line with the spirit of the age, through which model and texts can be created that can be used to build a new life that is potentially possible. This goal can only be achieved through this technique by opening up the horizons of literary texts in all their diversity to enrich the creative process¹. This process could only be realized on the ground through the mobilization of an ideology that seeks to break free from the constraints of convention and calls for complete liberation from the rote dependence on the texts themselves. Experimentation is

a constant attempt to "break new ground, and this attempt means giving reality a creative and dynamic character"⁽²⁾ in line with its constant and continuous changes.

Those familiar with what experimentation seeks to achieve in creative texts will find that it is constantly searching to embody new techniques that differ from the familiar literary reality in the construction of its structure and style through various techniques, including breaking the traditional structure of the event,

manipulating narrative time, multiple voices and perspectives, and the intermingling of literary genres. These techniques seek to establish a sense of surprise () for this new competent other reader's culture, which is what those familiar with Algerian fiction find when they step outside the circle of familiarity they are accustomed to, based on the fictional texts of Rida Houhou, Abdelhamid Ben Haddouqa, Tahar Wattar, Mustafa Fassi, Abdallah Raki, and even the texts of Alaoua Koussa, Badis Fougali, and others. Those familiar with Algerian fiction find a stark difference in the tone of literary writing, as the language and function of art are no longer "limited to repeating political/ideological discourse, but also an opportunity to identify the "self" with others, an opportunity to understand the world and participate in changing it, but without losing sight of its magical aesthetic dimension, because it can not achieve this goal except through its beauty and charm"³. This is what the story has presented throughout its different periods and through its ideologically diverse writers.

Researchers studying contemporary Algerian fiction find that writers have moved beyond the constraints of history to explore social issues that affect Arabs in general and Algerians in particular. The latter has not limit edit self to imitate in greality and the individual's hopes and pains, but has gone beyond that to an implicit reading that requires a competent reader who can go beyond the fence of the unspoken to interrogate it, which embodies experimentation and openness to multiple conceptual visions and meaning srather than a single meaning .Contemporary narrative discourse can be considered a **foundational structure for another phase in contemporary Algerian Arabic fiction, moving away from the authority of the model towards**

experimentation and openness, and destroying the dogmatic, monolithic nature of ideological discourse. It unifies artistically to model a movement that opposes the ready- made ,and aspires to the effectiveness of interpretation, or rather to the destruction of the classical narrative charter in order to reach a time of difference and surprise, and to leap over the separation between genres, that is, to the poetics of narrative discourse"⁴ .

The contemporary storyteller is determined to break out of the mold of the familiar and move toward the unfamiliar by transcending the conventional dynamics of narrative writing and engaging in dialogue with the text through the destruction of the narrative convention that both the writer and the reader have been taught, in order to present new narrative models that differ from the conventional approach and are in line with the requirements of the

contemporary moment and the orientations of readers of different cultures.

The reader cannot refute the unified idea presented by Algerian storytellers in past periods and eras, namely that of starting from reality in weaving their creative narrative texts. From this point, the idea of difference emerged through its deconstruction and transition to a starting point of transcendence and involving the recipient in the formulation of the narrative work's premises by introducing the idea of surprise and drawing the reader into the chaos of searching for the desired and intended meaning through the presentation of texts that are completely contrary to the narrative's automatic movement, which confuses the reader's expectations, by formulating new proposals starting with language ,structure ,and images and using the mina new way that is far from the usual, to form a unique textual world. This is achieved by incorporating implicit and explicit patterns into Contemporary narrative texts thats educe the reader, capture their thoughts, and distract them from the general concept of the text by engaging them and their past and present cultural knowledge in dismantling the mines planted between the folds of the story and attempting to familiarize them with the of the events and characters of the story through the characteristics of revelation and concealment employed by the text, which skill fully uses them to create an implicit pattern that is like **an "old germ that becomes active when it finds ther ight conditions "**⁵,which the contemporary text provides in order to break with convention by plant in gmeaning at the heart of the text,so that the hidden pattern becomes **"the system of**

values and ideologies that are concealed under the mask of a esthetic sin the structure of the text"⁶. Those familiar with it can discern the ideology it aims for under the name of aesthetics in order to understand the hidden meaning.

requires the reader to analyze the deep structure of the text and what the patterns imply of a culture that has been killed in the corridors of the aesthetic pattern. Reading the literary text is a cultural reading that goes beyond the apparent to the hidden, exposing what has been said to what I really want to say. This is what the reader finds in the short story collection **"Captivating Wrinkles"** by Algerian storyteller **Mohamed Kamel Ben**



Zid. The collection presents a comprehensive experimental model, starting with the new approach taken by the author in presenting his short stories, through to the hidden meanings that require the reader's skill in unravelling the unsaid and the margins within each individual story, which reflect the author's vision of contemporary reality. This experimentation is not limited to the formal aspect, but extends to the depth of the semantic and cultural structure of the collection.

Mohamed Kamel Ben Zid belongs to a generation of contemporary Algerian writers who witnessed profound social and cultural transformations in the last decades of the 20th century and the beginning of the

21st century. His creative approach is characterized by a clear tendency toward experimentation and the search for new forms of expression that correspond to the nature of the transformations experienced by contemporary Algerian society.

The short story collection **"Captivating Wrinkles"** is an example of experimental writing that goes beyond traditional forms, characterized by advanced artistic features including diversification in narrative techniques and attention to the psychological and social dimensions of the characters. Published in 2016, the collection is 62 pages long. In it, the author presents the essence of his storytelling experience through his work on form and content. Based on the former, the collection of short stories presents, starting from the cover, the first aesthetic features to capture the knowledgeable reader through the use of color and imagery.

The title, written in red and far from the moderate font, presented an unclear picture of its content; **wrinkles** are usually associated with elderly people who are advanced in age and worn out by life, while the word **"captivating"** suggests confinement or imprisonment, prompting the reader to interpret the hidden meaning. Not far from it, the painting formed a concept or image contrary to the title, as it contained an image of a young woman with her eyes closed, as if she were displaying features of youth completely devoid of wrinkles or any creases around the eyes and mouth, hidden in the middle of a mosaic that suggests she is wearing traditional Bedouin clothing. All of this was presented in yellow and blue; the former signifies eternity, while yellow signifies **"decline, old age, and the approach of death. Taken to its extreme, yellow becomes a substitute for black"**⁷, while blue signifies emptiness and purity or, in the

words of **Claude Abid** , **"entering into blue is a little like Alice in Wonderland (...)"**⁸ because of the surprises it holds, which are dependent on the idea that the reader is meant to grasp. The color also suggests **"the idea of calm and peaceful immortality, the superhuman,"**⁹ which opens the door to interpretations for readers who must arm themselves with renewed cultural and intellectual knowledge to decipher the gaps between these two mixed colors and their meanings on the cover and between the lines of the stories presented. The cover did not stop at the two colors mentioned above, but went beyond them to include a considerable amount of white, which contained the red and black colors, with white completely dominating, always and forever associated with **"a symbol of serenity, familiarity, cleanliness, purity, and clarity (...)"**¹⁰. However, this whiteness expressed on the cover page was not left alone, but was interrupted by the colors black and red, which clouded its purity. Although black is associated with mourning, depth, and obscurity, its meaning within the cover of the work was linked to authority and power¹¹ through the author's name at the top of the cover page as a form of control. The word "stories" appears in small print next to the title on the left, specifying the nature of this literary work.

On the other hand, the red color that adorns the title represents **"the color of the soul, the color of desire, the color of the heart"**¹² . Despite its association with these connotations, its meaning and significance in relation to the collection of stories remains subject to interpretation and what each story presents individually. This falls within the framework of experimentation that has become characteristic of contemporary works, especially since readers have become accustomed to understanding the general concept of a work based on its title, while postmodernism has introduced different

concepts to works and readers, especially since most works have turned to pronouns instead of disclosure as a new type of writing.

The experimentation within the short story collection under study is diverse, as the reader notices deliberate blank pages and striking titles through which the storyteller relies on strangeness and contrast to break the reader's expectations between the title and the textual meaning. An analytical reading of the collection reveals a striking presence of experimentation mechanisms on two overlapping levels: form and content. At the level of form, the stories in the collection are characterized by a break with the traditional plot structure, as they do not follow the classic sequence of events from beginning to middle to end. Instead, they rely on techniques of dreams, memories, and associations to construct a complex and intertwined narrative fabric.

The diversity of narrative styles stands out as one of the most important features of experimentation in the collection. The storyteller moves between different narrative voices, using new techniques that create a fresh narrative rhythm and keep the reader alert and interested.

In terms of content, the stories in the collection address contemporary issues in an unconventional way, interweaving the realistic with the symbolic. The storyteller draws on folk and cultural heritage in a modern and innovative way, creating a rich dialogue between the past and the present. This drawing on heritage does not stop at superficial references, but delves deeper into reinterpreting and re-reading the text in light of contemporary reality.

1 Experimenting with the implications of titles:

Titles form the thresholds of texts, allowing readers to access them and learn, even if only a little, about their contents. Readers of the stories in this collection may find discrepancies in terms of how closely the

titles relate to their contents or how far they stray from them. The collection opens with the story **"The Dinosaur's Dance,"** a title that makes the reader smile. Does a dinosaur have a dance, and if so, has anyone seen it? However, those who delve into its content will find some fragments of the title in the story through the aging of an unknown person who achieved everything but did not achieve his childhood dream, which was achieved by his son. Perhaps the connection between the title and the content is that dinosaurs lived for a long time, which is consistent with the character in the story, who is an old man, as the narrator says: **"He took a deep breath and then repeated in a very heavy tone: 'Oh, this damn gray hair! (...) The reflection of the sun sneaking through the window...made him feel that his image reflected a lot of sorrow and lamentation. His hair, his mustache, his beard... thick white hair swept over the dry and green... frightening and strange wrinkles spread across his entire face... leading him to one question from which other questions branched out. How did he spend his life?'"¹³**

The story continues, but the underlying theme remains an open discussion about the father's unfulfilled dream of heroism, which remains a subject of inquiry for the reader: what kind of heroism did the character seek? Athletic heroism, moral heroism, or some other unspoken kind of heroism? The titles of the stories: **Selfie, Small Lips, Daesh Dream, Negative, Dream of Sleep for Sale, Cartoon Face, Fog, and The Vision** on one point, namely that the reader begins to understand the story from the title, which each time forms the key to accessing and understanding the content, despite his attempts each time to understand the hidden meanings; The thresholds often deliberately misled the reader of the stories through titles that sometimes suggested positivity and sometimes negativity, which required a

reader who was contemporary with the ideological shifts taking place, who followed the major historical shifts or turning points, and who was competent and skilled in the art of searching for what was not said within what was said.

2 Experimentation in character subtext:

The reader of the short story collection under study encounters a strange pattern in the weaving of the stories, which are united in the illusion of the character; they reflect contradictory selves under an undeclared threat that depends on the construction of an unclear identity, which is how all the stories come together. The storyteller did not provide any clear hints about the characters who shaped the scenes of the stories; they were presented in complete obscurity, and it is up to the contemporary reader to piece together the scattered ideas and hallucinations presented by each character individually and form a general understanding of the story, which often remains without a specific and clear concept.

The reader of the story **"Selfie"** finds a hasty introduction and an unannounced uprising by an unknown character who asks the other characters—also unknown to the reader—to take a selfie. The story presents its scene with the narrator saying:

He came rushing from afar... People were pushing and shoving him relentlessly... He told himself: It doesn't matter... Everything else is insignificant... These are my loved ones.

How they got here and when they arrived doesn't matter... This is a priceless opportunity... It's been so long since he last saw them all together at the same time... In one place...He waved his hands high and urged them, "Come on, follow me, let's take a selfie. I bought a new cell phone from the popular market. He asked them to stand close together, smiling, so that the lens could capture them all.He insisted that they make the most of the moment. They were

overcome with joy. They forgot what they had been before his wild desire was satisfied. They were overcome with nostalgia for the old days and joined hands in childlike joy. Who would see the photo first? "14

This passage plunges the reader into a whirlwind of interpretation and search for the truth about these people: are they important journalists, work colleagues, or members of the same family? The reader continues to speculate and search for the hidden meaning, arriving at an idea that brings them closer to the truth about these characters after finding the phone's memory full and that the reason for this fullness is a repeated image of the child **"Aylan... the little boy who was washed up on the beach... drowned.**

They remained silent for a few more moments, their eyes heavy with grief. They fidgeted for a long time, then withdrew. No two were alike.¹⁵

Perhaps the reader's surprise did not last long, as the storyteller breaks the horizon of expectation with the character of the child who stirred public opinion in previous years, revealing the drowned child to the reader and bringing them closer to the possibility of these characters working in journalism.

Not far from the story of Selvi, the story of **Negatif** is presented, full of contradictions and strangeness. With the same ambiguity as before, the storyteller begins to introduce the character of his story, saying: **"His gaze wandered and quickly slipped into a gelatinous darkness... A harsh tremor seized his frail body... In the jungles of bitter time... He received a photograph of himself from the photographer... He swore with what seemed like an absolute certainty that it was him... Then he said, flashing a silly smile... (I swear by God... that it's you)... He looked closely at the picture, examining it over and over again, and pursed his lips in surprise. He repeated**

the question with deadly bitterness and a breath held to the utmost limit... (Is this really me?)... This was not the case a few moments ago... His jokes used to cause a noisy commotion of laughter and merriment in the waiting room... "16 .

In the same style and with the same ambiguity, the reader encounters another story whose details and characters are unknown, and once again finds himself wondering about this character. Is he a clown whose intense disguise in colors prevented him from recognizing himself when a real picture of

him was taken away from his embellished world, or is he a person whose features have been changed by the years and whose misery has made him someone other than the person he is looking for and wants? The reader continues to unravel the mysteries, and the storyteller adds to their depth, saying:

"(...) He approaches the mirror, preceded by a glimmer of hope, longing for a beautiful story from the past... (Unbelievable... This is me... Where is he? People, what is happening?)... A terrifying volcano suddenly erupts... His gaze, charged with the pain of misery, darts rapidly between the photograph and the mirror... He categorically rejects the idea of returning home, then advances with great agitation toward the photographer to force him to enter the darkroom with him... reminding him to make sure he does his job right this time... (I want it... me... only me)... while another burst of laughter spreads through the waiting room... and a silent word tries to cross the street...(A good man) "17 ; this passage intersects with a general scene from life that anyone in the public encounters, where what a person conceals contradicts what he declares, whether joy or sadness, and it is the open secret that neither the storyteller nor the reader has provided an explanation for,

other than a set of endless interpretations, including the man's madness.

3 Experimentation in the hidden meanings of space and time and the gaps:

Perhaps one of the characteristics of the experimentation with hidden meanings in the short story collection *Tajawud Asila* is that its texts carry multiple and overlapping hidden patterns. The first is the social pattern, which reveals the contradictions and crises experienced by contemporary Algerian society through its characters and events, where the storyteller observes a state of social and cultural fragmentation that reflects the effects of globalization and modernity on the traditional structures of society.

Second is the cultural theme, which reflects the identity conflict between authenticity and modernity. This duality is evident in the characters of the stories, who experience a fragmentation of identity and attempt to reconcile their authentic cultural belonging with the demands of the modern era. This conflict takes many forms in the texts, from psychological conflict to the conflict between traditional and modern values.

The existential theme also finds its place in the constant questioning of the meaning of life, death, and memory. The stories in the collection raise profound questions about the individual's relationship with themselves and the world around them, in a context characterized by rapid change and uncertainty. This existential dimension gives the texts a philosophical depth that transcends traditional narrative to the level of contemplation and fundamental human questioning, leaving the reader confused as they seek to understand and search for the intended meaning. Those seeking something new in **the short story writer's** texts will find that they vary according to the new intellectual system of writers and readers on which society is based. The short stories are presented in a new and different

format, prompting the short story writer's audience to uncover the hidden ideologies and implicit values conveyed by his texts.

To achieve this stage, it is necessary to delve deeply into the story to reach the hidden layers of meaning and reveal the different cultural and social patterns each time, in order to understand the social and cultural context in which the texts are produced and received, which is what the reader finds when following the threads of all the stories in the blog. The experimentation touched

on the form, and the reader who follows the content of the story scenes finds that the storyteller has undermined the classic plot. by reconstructing the narrative line based on dreams and disappearance, so that as soon as the reader grasps the intended meaning, they encounter something that distracts them and takes them in another direction. The storyteller has also gone beyond the idea of specifying time and place, putting pressure on the reader to reconstruct the meaning themselves, trying to find an imaginary time and place to approach the details of the events. However, this reconstruction breaks down in some stories that briefly and fleetingly refer to the time and place of certain events, such as in the story "**Small Lips**," when the protagonist says:

"Only one of them approached me, holding a digital camera in his hands, and whispered in my ear:

'We want a group photo of us...

Yesterday, after school ended and just hours before the war, according to my student register, there were thirty students, even the student (×) who usually skips class was present and very active..."¹⁸ . The reader must delve into deciphering the codes of time and place.

In contrast to the previous trend, I presented a story: **A Dream of Slumber... For sale** to the reader, clear features of time and place are revealed in the hero's words:

"Questions I asked myself after I woke

up from my ecstasy... from my slumber... on top of this forgotten hill overlooking my town of Biskra from the side of the Aures Mountains... unlike my usual self...I forgot myself, lying on the ground, exhausted after a month of work (...) I didn't notice the wheels of my car driving me here after Friday prayers... I longed for this solitude... I thought I would love it and it would love me back..."¹⁹ . This is consistent with the story: The vision came true, which presented the details of time and place in a simple manner, leaving it up to the reader to grasp the idea of the scene with the hero's words:

"On the morning of the feast... A pleasant smell filled the air... Accompanied by lots of laughter and conversations stretching across the long street ... La'tila Street..."²⁰

The stories in the collection agreed to include the reader's culture to complete the meaning of the story or clarify its general scene within the policy of experimenting with content; The stories address contemporary issues in symbolic ways, such as emotional alienation, existential frustrations, and the collapse of collective memory, without directly addressing them. These stories transcend the conventional narrative style by incorporating various implicit patterns into the texts, including The social theme was represented by the portrayal of the fragility of human relationships and the absence of social solidarity, with the individual appearing as a confused loner facing reality alone, as embodied in **the story of the cartoon face**. The existential theme questioned the meanings of life and death, memory, and human destiny, as woven into **the story of the fog**.

The implicit experimentation within the stories under study did not stop at what has been mentioned, but went beyond it to what is known as silent culture, through a policy of emptiness or whiteness that leaves the

reader space to gather their thoughts and piece together their expectations. No story is without the two dots (...) and the white spaces that end or separate the stories, the purpose of which is to allow the reader to organize the chaos that has taken hold of him from the previous story and to organize his thoughts to face the new narrative fabric that requires deep digging into the layers of the text to reach the hidden meanings.

Perhaps what can be said at the end of this intervention is that **The Algerian** storyteller's experience represents an advanced experimental narrative based on deconstructing the formal structure of the narrative in favor of a new aesthetic construction that reveals the depth of the social, cultural, and existential crisis. This aesthetic dimension is inseparable from an ideological consciousness that rejects fixed patterns and opens the text to multiple readings and interpretations through its multiple narrative models. The storyteller uses the socialism of reality to guide the reader to the deeper structure without confiscating their interpretation, which makes his literature close to the particularities of experimentation but with a clear local identity. Thus, the short stories transform the distance between text and reality into a new horizon for critical cultural awareness ; through the textual structure on which the stories are built and the disruption of the linearity of time and space, as well as the ambiguity that surrounds the characters and events, which are transformed or reduced to a single event, contributing to the creation of an atmosphere full of surprises.

Margins:

¹See: Omar Al-Asri: The Story and the Experiment: A Study of the Works of Anis Al-Rafei, Athar Publications, Morocco, 1st edition, 2013, p. 11.

²Adonis: The Time of Poetry, Dar Al-Awda, Beirut, Lebanon, 1st edition, 1983, p. 287.

³Makhloof, Amer: Manifestations of Renewal in the Short Story in Algeria, Arab Writers Union Publications, Damascus, Syria, 1998, pp. 10, 11.

⁴Abdul Qadir Ben Salem: Components of Narrative in New Algerian Fiction, Arab Writers Union Publications, Damascus, 2001, p. 21.

⁵Hafnaoui Baali: An Introduction to the Theory of Comparative Cultural Criticism, Arab House of Sciences, Dar Al-Ikhtilaf Publications, 1st edition, 2007, Algeria, p. 50.

⁶Abdullah Al-Ghazami: Cultural Criticism: A Reading of Arab Cultural Patterns, Arab Cultural Center, Beirut, Lebanon, 3rd edition, 2005, p. 21.

⁷ Claude Obeid: The Meaning of Colors (Their Role, Classification, Sources, Symbolism, and Significance), reviewed

and presented by Muhammad Hamoud, Majd University Foundation for Studies, Publishing, and Distribution, Beirut, Lebanon, 1st edition, 2013, p. 110.

⁸Ibid.,p. 82.

⁹Ibid.,p. 82.

¹⁰Ibid.,p.61.

¹¹See *ibid.*,p. 66.

¹²Ibid.,p. 74.

¹³Mohammed al-Kamil bin Zaid: Wrinkles of a Family, Dar Ali bin Zaid for Printing and Publishing, Biskra, Algeria, 1st edition, 2016, p. 10.

¹⁴ Ibid.,p. 14.

¹⁵ Ibid.,p. 15.

¹⁶ Ibid.,p. 26.

¹⁷Ibid.,pp.26-27.

¹⁸Ibid.,pp.18-19.

¹⁹Ibid.,pp.30–31.

²⁰Ibid.,p. 48.